



THIS IS NOT YOUR BIGGEST WATER PROBLEM.

YOUR LAWN USES MORE WATER THAN AI.

170 times more, to be precise. Your anger at data centers is correct. This is where to aim it.

- ☐ The comparison you need, sourced and precise
- ☐ Why both problems have the same root cause
- ☐ What you can do today without a senator
- ☐ The commons argument that connects them
- ☐ A defense of AI water use
- ☐ Any suggestion your anger is wrong

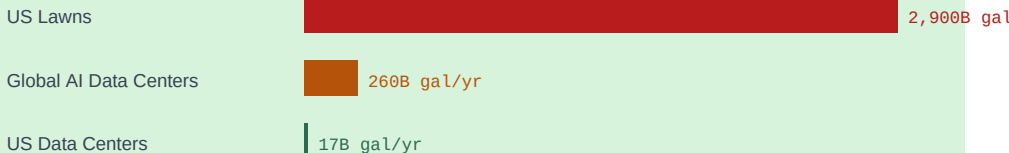
US LAWNS: ~2.9 TRILLION GAL/YR
US DATA CENTERS: ~17 BILLION GAL/YR

RATIO: ~170x

THE NUMBERS. PRECISELY.

Before the argument, the data. Every figure here is sourced. Check the bibliography at jason-edelman.org/abolish-lawns/bibliography.

ANNUAL US WATER CONSUMPTION BY SOURCE



Sources: Lawrence Berkeley Lab (Shehabi et al. 2024); EPA WaterSense; joshuaheathscott.substack.com

US lawn irrigation consumes approximately 2.9 trillion gallons per year. All US data centers combined consume approximately 17 billion gallons directly — about 170 times less. Including indirect water use from electricity generation raises data center consumption to around 211 billion gallons — still 14 times less than lawns.

Half of all lawn irrigation water evaporates before reaching roots. Data centers increasingly recycle cooling water and source non-potable supply. The trends are moving in opposite directions.

THE HONEST CAVEAT

Data center water use is a real problem — especially locally. A single Meta data center in Newton County, GA uses 10% of the entire county's water. These are not abstract national statistics for people whose aquifer is being drawn down. The national comparison does not cancel the local harm. Both are enclosures. Both deserve your anger. The lawn is the one you can act on today.

SAME ROOT CAUSE.

Data centers extract shared water resources for private profit, externalize the environmental costs onto local communities, and operate behind opacity and regulatory capture. Lawns extract shared water resources for the performance of conformity, externalize the ecological costs onto watersheds and downstream communities, and operate behind municipal ordinances and HOA covenants that make refusal costly.

Both are enclosures. The commons — shared water, shared ecological function, shared land — captured for private or corporate use with costs pushed onto everyone else.



THE DROUGHT YOUR LAWN IS MAKING WORSE.

THE DIFFERENCE IS LEVERAGE.

You cannot turn off a Meta data center. You can stop watering your lawn. Today. Right now. You can rip it out. You can plant something that supports pollinators, sequesters carbon, infiltrates stormwater, and does not require pesticide. You cannot petition Google's cooling tower. You can make your 40 million square feet of American lawn do something other than evaporate.

"America has a well-documented addiction to green grass that is also not serving us well."

— Lincoln Institute of Land Policy, 2026

The solution to both problems is the same: collective governance of shared resources instead of private extraction at public cost. Start with the one on your property.

ACT ON WHAT YOU CAN REACH. NOW.



Your senator isn't the only lever.

You don't need to choose between fighting data centers and fighting lawns. Both are the same fight. One of them you can start on your property this week.

STOP WATERING.

Now. Your lawn will go dormant, not dead. Calculate what you save. Post it.

PULL IT OUT.

Native plants, food, clover, bare earth — anything. Your front yard converted is an argument every neighbor has to walk past.

DOCUMENT THE PUSHBACK.

HOA notice? Neighbor complaint? Code enforcement? Make it public. Every enforcement action is free advertising for why this mandate needs to end.

CONNECT THE FIGHTS.

The same framework that lets corporations extract water from aquifers lets HOAs extract labor from homeowners. It's all enclosure. Name it.

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PRINT THIS. SHARE IT. PROPAGATE FREELY.